

CERTIFIED CIGAR SOMMELIER (CCS®)

MODULE 4 TEACHING MANUAL

BLENDER PHILOSOPHIES & RH FAMILIES

Status: Core Module – Mandatory

Applies to: CCS® Level I & ACS® Level II

Estimated Study Load: 3 Hours

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13. MODULE SUMMARY

MODULE PURPOSE

Many cigar smokers assume cigars behave primarily according to:

- country of origin,
- wrapper color,

- or advertised strength level.

Professional cigar analysis requires a more advanced approach.

This module teaches candidates that cigar behaviour is largely determined by:

- blender philosophy,
- combustion design,
- tobacco selection,
- fermentation strategy,
- and construction engineering.

Candidates will learn how to:

- identify the design intent behind a cigar,
- classify cigars into Relative Humidity (RH) Families,
- and predict peak flavour behaviour before smoking.

This is one of the most important professional modules in the CCS® framework because it transforms cigar evaluation from:

reactive smoking

into:

predictive analysis.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this module, the candidate shall be able to:

1. Explain why blender philosophy matters more than country of origin
2. Identify combustion and construction signals within different cigar styles
3. Classify cigars into RH Families accurately
4. Predict approximate peak-flavour RH for unfamiliar cigars
5. Explain behavioural differences between similar cigars
6. Avoid common classification myths and folklore

SECTION 1

WHY BLENDERS MATTER MORE THAN ORIGIN

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Why This Matters Professionally

Many consumers rely heavily on country stereotypes such as:

- “Nicaraguan cigars are strong,”
- “Dominican cigars are mild,”
- or “Cuban cigars smoke best wetter.”

These assumptions are often incomplete and professionally unreliable.

Two cigars from:

- the same country,
- the same factory,
- or even the same brand

can behave very differently depending on how the cigar was designed.

Professional cigar service requires understanding:

how the cigar was engineered to combust.

1.1 The Myth of Country-Based Prediction

Country of origin may provide clues about:

- climate,
- soil type,
- seed availability,
- and general flavour style.

However, origin alone does not determine:

- combustion temperature,
- moisture tolerance,
- flavour-release behaviour,
- or peak smoking RH.

Those characteristics are influenced more heavily by:

- priming selection,

- fermentation style,
- wrapper structure,
- filler density,
- and blender intent.

Two cigars from the same factory may require completely different humidity management.

1.2 The Blender as Combustion Architect

The blender controls:

- which leaves are selected,
- how those leaves are fermented,
- how the cigar is rolled,
- how combustion progresses,
- and what sensory experience the smoker receives.

In practical terms, the blender is designing:

- a combustion system,
- a flavour-delivery system,
- and a moisture-response system.

This design philosophy determines how the cigar responds to humidity.

RH Families are therefore not random categories.

They are behavioural systems created through cigar construction.

SECTION 2

UNDERSTANDING RH FAMILIES

2.1 What Is an RH Family?

An **RH Family** is a group of cigars that share:

- similar combustion behaviour,
- similar moisture tolerance,

- and similar peak-flavour RH ranges.

RH Families are based on:

- cigar performance,
not geography.

2.2 Why RH Families Matter

Without RH Families:

- every cigar must be learned individually,
- prediction becomes difficult,
- and expertise develops very slowly.

RH Families allow the sommelier to:

- classify unfamiliar cigars quickly,
- estimate ideal RH ranges,
- predict flavour behaviour,
- and troubleshoot more effectively.

This creates scalable professional expertise.

Professional Perspective

A trained sommelier should eventually be able to:

- examine a cigar,
- assess its construction,
- and predict how it will behave before smoking it.

That predictive ability is one of the defining differences between:

- casual smokers,
and
- trained cigar professionals.

SECTION 3

RH FAMILY A - CLARITY-DRIVEN / AROMATIC

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Typical Peak-Flavour RH: 59–61%

3.1 Design Philosophy

This family prioritizes:

- aroma clarity,
- flavour precision,
- evolution,
- and refined combustion behaviour.

These cigars are often designed to:

- burn slightly hotter,
- release volatile aromatics efficiently,
- and reward careful moisture control.

They tend to emphasize:

- nuance,
- transition,
- and flavour definition

over raw power.

3.2 Common Construction Signals

Typical indicators include:

- thinner wrappers,
- lower oil content,
- moderate filler density,
- cooler or longer fermentation,
- and greater seco/viso emphasis.

These cigars are often engineered for:

- aromatic expression rather than combustion buffering.
-

3.3 Combustion Behaviour

Because these cigars rely heavily on aromatic release:

- excess moisture can suppress flavour clarity,
- smoke texture may become dull,
- and combustion efficiency may decline quickly.

These cigars are generally less tolerant of over-humidification.

What the Smoker Will Notice

At proper RH:

- flavours feel precise,
- transitions remain clean,
- sweetness becomes more visible,
- and aromas evolve clearly.

Above peak RH:

- flavours become muted,
 - complexity collapses,
 - and the cigar may feel flat despite smoothness.
-

3.4 Examples

Examples provided:

- on demand during practical instruction.
-

3.5 Common Student Errors

Common mistakes include:

- storing these cigars too wet,
- assuming “mild” means forgiving,
- and confusing smoothness with proper performance.

These cigars are often among the most RH-sensitive cigars in professional service.

SECTION 4

RH FAMILY B - BALANCED BOUTIQUE

Typical Peak-Flavour RH: 61–62%

4.1 Design Philosophy

This family aims for:

- balance,
- texture,
- sweetness,
- and controlled complexity.

These cigars are typically designed to:

- balance aromatic clarity with body,
- tolerate moderate moisture variation,
- and perform consistently across multiple environments.

This is one of the most versatile RH Families.

4.2 Common Construction Signals

Typical indicators include:

- medium wrapper thickness,
- moderate oil presence,
- balanced filler structures,
- and hybrid fermentation approaches.

These cigars often seek equilibrium rather than extremes.

4.3 Combustion Behaviour

This family usually demonstrates:

- stable combustion,

- predictable progression,
- and moderate RH tolerance.

However, flavour degradation still becomes noticeable outside the intended RH band.

Precision still matters.

What the Smoker Will Notice

At proper RH:

- sweetness, body, and aroma feel integrated,
- combustion feels stable,
- and transitions remain balanced.

When improperly humidified:

- the cigar may lose either:
 - flavour precision,
 - or combustion control.

4.4 Examples

Examples provided:

- on demand during practical instruction.

4.5 Professional Implications

This family is often:

- ideal for training environments,
- highly adaptable in lounges,
- and less polarizing for consumers.

However:

approachable does not mean maintenance-free.

These cigars still require professional RH management.

SECTION 5

RH FAMILY C - POWER / LIGERO-HEAVY

Typical Peak-Flavour RH: 63–65%

5.1 Design Philosophy

This family prioritizes:

- richness,
- strength,
- smoke density,
- and mouthfeel.

These cigars are often designed to:

- combust more slowly,
- buffer stronger tobaccos,
- and moderate nicotine delivery.

Higher RH often helps stabilize combustion in this family.

5.2 Common Construction Signals

Typical indicators include:

- heavy ligero use,
- thick oily wrappers,
- dense rolling,
- and deeper or warmer fermentation styles.

These cigars are often engineered for:

- power,
 - texture,
 - and combustion buffering.
-

5.3 Combustion Behaviour

These cigars generally respond poorly to excessive dryness.

When too dry:

- combustion heat rises rapidly,
- pepper sharpens,
- nicotine feels aggressive,
- and flavour balance collapses.

Moderately higher RH helps:

- slow combustion,
- smooth smoke texture,
- and preserve flavour integration.

What the Smoker Will Notice

At proper RH:

- smoke feels dense but controlled,
- strength feels integrated,
- and sweetness remains intact beneath the power.

Below peak RH:

- harshness increases quickly,
- flavour layering disappears,
- and combustion becomes overly aggressive.

5.4 Examples

Examples provided:

- on demand during practical instruction.

5.5 Common Misdiagnosis

Many smokers incorrectly interpret:

- harshness as intentional strength,

- or pepper as premium richness.

In reality, many powerful cigars simply become unstable when under-humidified.

These cigars often require moisture buffering to perform correctly.

SECTION 6

HYBRID & EDGE-CASE CIGARS

6.1 Why Hybrid Behaviour Exists

Some blenders intentionally create cigars that combine characteristics from multiple RH Families.

This may be done to:

- broaden consumer appeal,
- create transitional flavour styles,
- or increase versatility across environments.

These cigars often require:

- more careful staging,
- tighter RH control,
- and more observational smoking.

6.2 How to Classify Hybrid Cigars

When classifying hybrids, professionals should prioritize:

1. Wrapper behaviour
2. Filler density
3. Fermentation style

Marketing language should never be treated as primary evidence.

Avoid relying on:

- colour descriptors,
- country stereotypes,
- or advertising terminology.

SECTION 7

RAPID PROFESSIONAL CLASSIFICATION

Rapid Classification Method

When evaluating an unfamiliar cigar:

Step 1

Assess:

- wrapper thickness,
- wrapper oiliness,
- and surface texture.

Step 2

Estimate:

- filler density,
- combustion resistance,
- and likely fermentation depth.

Step 3

Consider:

- blender philosophy,
- intended smoking style,
- and target consumer profile.

Step 4

Assign a provisional RH Family.

Step 5

Validate through smoking diagnostics.

This process allows:

- predictive preparation,
- faster troubleshooting,

- and more consistent cigar service.

SECTION 8

APPLIED PROFESSIONAL SCENARIOS

Scenario 1 - New Brand in a Lounge

Situation

A new cigar brand enters the humidor.

Professional Approach

- Assess construction signals,
- assign provisional RH family,
- stage conservatively,
- and validate through controlled smoking.

Scenario 2 - Customer Dislikes a Premium Cigar

Situation

A customer dislikes a cigar they were expected to enjoy.

Professional Approach

- Evaluate RH-family mismatch,
- reassess preparation conditions,
- and adjust humidity strategy before changing brands.

This preserves:

- customer trust,
- service quality,
- and diagnostic accuracy.

SECTION 9

EXAMINATION ALIGNMENT

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Candidates must be able to:

- classify cigars into RH Families,
 - justify classifications causally,
 - explain combustion differences,
 - and avoid origin-based assumptions.
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Common Examination Errors

Candidates often:

- rely too heavily on country stereotypes,
- confuse wrapper colour with combustion behaviour,
- trust brand prestige over construction evidence,
- or assume stronger cigars always require lower RH.

Professional analysis must remain:

- combustion-based,
 - observational,
 - and evidence-driven.
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SECTION 10

CORE PROFESSIONAL PRINCIPLES

Candidates should be able to defend the following statements:

1. Blender philosophy determines combustion behaviour.
 2. RH Families are behavioural systems, not geographic categories.
 3. Moisture tolerance is intentionally designed into a cigar.
 4. Misclassification causes many smoking failures.
 5. Predictive RH classification is a hallmark of professional expertise.
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MODULE SUMMARY

This module establishes that:

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- cigars cluster into recognizable behavioural families,
- those families reflect blender intent,
- peak-flavour RH can often be estimated before smoking,
- and professional cigar management becomes scalable through classification.

The sommelier therefore moves from:

“I’ll smoke it and see.”

to:

“I understand how this cigar is likely to behave before ignition.”

